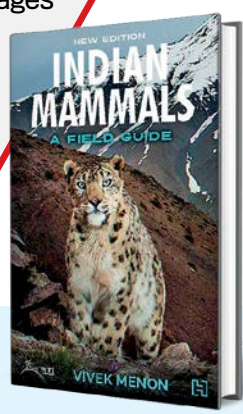


TERMITE FRY
by Zai Whitaker
BLOOMSBURY
INDIA
₹499;
200 pages

INDIAN MAMMALS: A Field Guide
by Vivek Menon
HACHETTE INDIA
₹1,299;
544 pages



Guardians of the Forest

Zai Whitaker's *Termite Fry* captures the eternal tussle between urban aspirations and traditional forest communities

Zai Whitaker is truly a gem among contemporary Indian writers—her vast knowledge of animals and the natural world, her compassion for her characters, her gentle wit and ability to create an intimacy with our living environment are extraordinary. Every single one of her works is imbued with a feeling of wonder at the infinite diversity of the world around us, a feeling that she offers to her readers with a charming ease and grace.

Termite Fry is the story of a family of Irulars and their traditional community of snake-catchers in Tamil Nadu who interact with the modern world primarily through the sale of forest products, including snakeskins. Faced with a devastating blow to their livelihood by the restrictions on the snakeskin trade in the 1970s, the Irulars are partially resurrected years later by becoming the only source of snake venom, a precious antidote to lethal snakebites. Whitaker has worked closely with the Irulars and here, she weaves her respect for them and for all they have taught her into a deceptively simple story that is simultaneously an elegy for the wisdom that we have disdained and a clarion call to preserve what we have left.

Tuned to the smallest shifts in the wind and finding meaning in every sound from the shrublands of their habitat, the Irulars live in a symbiotic relationship with nature. Their universe of knowledge and ecosystem could not be further from the city and its urban aspirations. And yet, it is these very aspirations, so faraway and so alien, that most brutally affect the communities that do not even share them. In this story, a small family unit functions as a microcosm for the larger community that is exploited by city agents and buyers even as they resolutely try to preserve their lives that depend on hunting and gathering and community ownership of the 'commons'. Thatha, a shaman, embodies the old ways but, more than anyone else, he encourages his precocious granddaughter, Thenee, who is determined to go to school so that she can counter the systemic manipulations that cheat her people.

Whitaker's *Termite Fry* is like the people it writes about—unobtrusive, ruminative, rooted in what it knows and confident of the importance of what it has to say. It reminds us that the loudest noises often point only to themselves and that it is the flutter of wings that alerts us to the sweetness of birdsong. ■

Arshia Sattar

While volunteering on a conservation project in Arunachal Pradesh, I chanced upon a curious bushy-tailed creature that resembled a squirrel but for its pointy snout. An inquiring text to a wildlife expert produced the necessary identification: *Tupaia belangeri*, the northern tree shrew, an insectivorous mammal more closely related to primates than rodents. That expert was Vivek Menon, executive director of Wildlife Trust of India and an award-winning conservationist, environmental commentator, author and photographer.

Menon's capacious wisdom is compiled in the second edition of his field guide to Indian mammals, updated after five reprints of the first. Although at least 440 mammal species can be found in India, most visitors to our national parks will probably recognise 10. The big-bucks business of wildlife tourism is preoccupied with charismatic megafauna like large carnivores, rhinos and elephants.

The world of mammals is a fascinating one. From airborne bats to aquatic whales, from gargantuan elephants to minuscule shrews, they inhabit every ecosystem from forest, grassland, mountain and desert, to marine, riverine, coastal and mangrove habitats. As wild habitats are increasingly lost to human activity and climate change, consequently, so are their inhabitants. Perhaps that's why learning about mammals is vital for our survival, and the 40-odd introductory pages set the context. There are helpful hints for exploring habitats, investigating tracks, telling apart sexes, understanding age, and the decorum to observe while visiting protected areas.

All sections, particularly those on bats and cetaceans, are well-researched, with pointers to locations where these animals can be observed. In addition to species pages, which are enriched with distribution maps, anatomy diagrams, evolutionary trees and factoids, the book is a treasure of field notes. Menon's prowess as a vigilant anti-trafficking activist comes to the fore as he introduces some species as we may commonly encounter them—hunted and sold for the pot in wet markets.

The book provides comprehensive endnotes for further reading. Updated with redrawn maps of Ladakh and Telangana, and notes on the import of cheetahs from Namibia, it does its best to be current. The information-packed layout feels cramped, though, and, in places, the text was a strain on my eyes.

In the age of Google Lens and AI apps, the printed field guide is an endangered species. Yet, does wildlife discovery end with identification? *Indian Mammals: A Field Guide* is a valuable companion on your next wild outing to get you thinking about conservation. ■

Bijoy Venugopal